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Wormholes and Time Machines[1]

in which the author seeks insight
into physical laws by asking:
can highly advanced civilizations
build wormholes through hyperspace
for rapid interstellar travel
and machines for traveling backward in time?

Wormholes and Exotic Material

I had just taught my last class of the 1984–85 academic year and was sinking into my office chair to let the adrenaline subside, when the telephone rang. It was Carl Sagan, the Cornell University astrophysicist and a personal friend from way back. "Sorry to bother you, Kip," he said. "But I'm just finishing a novel about the human race's first contact with an extraterrestrial civilization, and I'm worried. I want the science to be as accurate as possible, and I'm afraid I may have got some of the gravitational physics wrong. Would you look at it and give me advice?" Of course I would. It would be interesting, since Carl is a clever guy. It might even be fun. Besides, how could I turn down this kind of request from a friend?

The novel arrived a couple of weeks later, a three-and-a-half-inch-thick stack of double-spaced typescript.

I slipped the stack into an overnight bag and threw the bag into the back seat of Linda's Bronco, when she picked me up for the long drive from Pasadena to Santa Cruz. Linda is my ex-wife; she, I, and our son Bret were on our way to see our daughter Kares graduate from college.